

Eastern gray squirrel
Sciurus carolinensis

- ↔ 9–11 in (23–28 cm)
- 📍 S. and SE. Canada to S. US, Europe
- ⊗ Common

Introduced to parts of Europe over a century ago, this North American tree squirrel has become an invasive species in many regions, displacing native squirrels. It is

an agile, resourceful, and opportunistic feeder, taking a wide variety of natural foods such as nuts, seeds, fruit, and fungi, as well as raiding bird feeders. The squirrel often hoards surplus food, carrying it in its mouth and burying it in scattered underground caches.



pale-gray to white ears

thick, bushy tail helps in balance

pale fur on underside

Cape ground squirrel
Xerus inauris

- ↔ 8–12 in (20–30 cm)
- 📍 Southern Africa
- ⊗ Common

Found in the semideserts of southern Africa, this bushy-tailed ground squirrel shelters from the midday heat in a burrow system dug with its strong claws. It lives in small colonies of up to 30 animals, feeding by day on a variety of plant matter such as seeds, bulbs, and roots, though it also takes insects and bird eggs. The squirrel extracts the water it needs from the food, so it rarely has to drink—a valuable asset in such a dry habitat.



Indian giant squirrel
Ratufa indica

- ↔ 14–16 in (35–40 cm)
- 📍 S. Asia
- ⊗ Common

Remarkable for its striking two-tone coloration—dark above and pale below—and its very long, bushy tail, the Indian giant squirrel is an agile climber that forages for fruit, nuts, insects, and eggs in the trees. It can leap up to 20 ft (6 m) between branches, enabling it to move from tree to tree without descending to ground level. It also sleeps and breeds in the trees, building a large nest (drey) of twigs and leaves.

Hazel dormouse
Muscardinus avellanarius

- ↔ 2–3 in (5–7.6 cm)
- 📍 Europe
- ⊗ Common

Widespread across Europe, the hazel dormouse is a small, bushy-tailed rodent that spends most of its time foraging in the trees. It searches for flowers, insect grubs, and bird eggs in spring and summer, then switches to fruit, nuts, and seeds before hibernating in a nest on the ground throughout the winter. The dormouse may also sink into a deep sleep to survive periods of bad weather or food scarcity in summer.

Large pocket gopher
Orthogeomys grandis

- ↔ 4–14 in (10–35 cm)
- 📍 Mexico to Central America
- ⊗ Locally common

Named for its external cheek pouches used for carrying food, this stocky rodent is specialized at burrowing, with large-clawed forefeet and permanently exposed incisor teeth for digging. It emerges above ground at night to feed on vegetation. Usually solitary, the large pocket gopher forms breeding groups of up to four females and one male. Each female bears two or more young.

Eurasian beaver
Castor fiber

- ↔ 33–39 in (83–100 cm)
- 📍 Europe to C. Asia
- ⊗ Common

Like its very similar American relative, the big, bulky European beaver is an aquatic rodent that uses its large, orange, chisel-like incisor teeth to gnaw through wood and fell small trees. The beaver uses these to dam streams, creating small lakes that surround and protect its stick-and-mud lodges. In areas with many natural waterways, however, it often makes a riverbank burrow with an underwater entrance.

